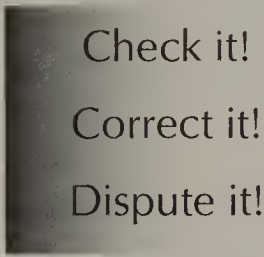


Review your three credit reports with a fine-tooth comb! Are there accounts you have never heard of? Are there amounts or information that appear incorrect? Compare the information on the credit report against your records. All it takes is a little bit of your time to make sure that the information is really yours and that it is accurate. And don't forget, time is money. Your money.



Check it!

Correct it!

Dispute it!

Errors in your personal information don't affect your credit score, but still need to be corrected. Errors, or strange information, like an oddball address, especially a P.O. Box that isn't yours, could be an indication someone else has access to your accounts. Identity theft is a very real threat and is becoming increasingly more and more common. Be vigilant in your efforts to protect yourself from identity theft. One of those efforts is to monitor your credit report. Do it at least once a year. Every few months is even better.

Initiate a Dispute

Errors are all over the credit reports, so be diligent in your search for mistakes. Find an error? File a dispute immediately!

The credit repair people try to make you believe that this is their area of expertise, and they will charge you to file a dispute. You don't have to pay anyone to do this for you! File a dispute, for free, online, over the phone, or by snail mail. Once you file a dispute, the credit reporting agency contacts the lender or the creditor or the credit card company.

If you file by writing a letter, make a copy of the current credit report. Highlight the credit report number, the date, and the actual error. Your letter needs to include your basic information, plus a copy of a current utility bill, showing your name and address, and a copy of your picture ID (passport or driver's license). Include a detailed explanation of each error, along with your statements, or whatever else you have to prove your dispute. Keep a copy of everything for your records.

The credit reporting agency has 30 days to resolve the dispute. If they cannot prove the error one way or another, the item you are